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COVID, flu are on rise, but fewer getting shots

Oldest and youngest particularly at risk

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

Lots of people in Massachusetts have skipped their flu and COVID-19 vaccines this season, especially those most vulnerable to serious complications if infected — older adults and young children.

The drop in vaccinations comes amid a rising tide of misinformation about vaccines and now a significant climb in the rate of infections. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Massachusetts is experiencing “moderate” rates of influenza and “high” rates of COVID-19 detected in waste water.

Now, as families and friends gather for the holidays, providing a fertile mix of travel, tight spaces, and close contact, health experts are bracing for lots more infections and misery.

“One of the things most concerning to me is not just that we are below where we were in prior seasons for vaccinations, it’s that we are plateauing earlier. If we were still on the upward trajectory for vaccinations, I would feel more confident,” said Dr. Robbie Goldstein, state public health commissioner.

It can take a couple of weeks for a vaccine to be fully effective, so the sooner people get shots, the better, Goldstein said.

Just 38 percent of children under 5, and less than two-thirds of people 65 to 79, have had their flu shot this season. For COVID, only

VACCINES, Page A10

As some senior Democrats go down, Neal holds strong

By Jim Puzzanghera
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The walls of Representative Richard Neal’s Capitol Hill office are covered with memorabilia — framed photos of him with famous politicians and commemorative copies of significant legislation he shepherded. One of his favorites is a vertical shot from the early 1990s of three dozen lawmakers seated on a long committee dais.

“As a very new member of the Ways and Means Committee, there I am on that front row,” Neal, 75, said one recent morning, pointing to a then-dark-haired version of himself. “I’m the last one [still here] from that picture.”

Such seniority and longevity aren’t particularly popular with House Democrats these days.

Younger members have pressed for more power after failing to win the majority in November in an effort many believe was dragged down by 82-year-old President Biden’s troubled performance before dropping out of the race. This month, three lawmakers in their 70s were toppled from their senior committee posts as part of internal leadership battles, and another veteran septuagenarian held off a strong challenge for an open slot from one of the youngest House Democrats, 35-year-old Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez.

NEAL, Page A6

‘The program is remarkable, and the people that we serve are also equally remarkable. Families are fleeing some of the worst situations that you can imagine.’

MARJEAN PERHOT, vice president of refugee and immigration services for Catholic Charities in Boston



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Parents Patricia Michalczuk and Cristian Palacios, and their son, Santiago, checked out their new apartment in Lowell.

For refugees, another obstacle

Many have thrived through US program, but its future could be in doubt under Trump

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio
GLOBE STAFF

LOWELL — It was 6-year-old Santiago’s first night in the United States, and on this early December evening it felt like Christmas as he gleefully sorted through the presents a refugee resettlement agency had left in his new bedroom.

“Look, Mom!” he cried every few minutes in Spanish, holding up one gift after the next: flashcards to learn numbers in English, a Curious George book, Kinder chocolates, a backpack for school.

As his parents, Patricia Michalczuk and Cristian Palacios, and his older sister, Tatiana, explored the corners of the apartment with a nonprofit resettlement volunteer, the fear that had stalked the family for so many years seeped into the questions they asked. Was the neighborhood calm? Would it be safe to walk outside? Was there a number they could call if anything happened that night?

“I’m happy, because I’m with my family. But we have been through a lot,” Michalczuk said in Spanish.

The family, who fled violent threats in Ven-

ezuela and then Ecuador over the last seven years, found their way to safety here through the United States Refugee Admissions Program, a lifeline for millions of people since 1980. The program allows refugees escaping dire humanitarian circumstances, including war, consequences of climate change, and persecution, to be flown legally to the United States after undergoing rigorous security checks over months or, more often, years. Many eventually become citizens.

But it’s not clear how much longer the

REFUGEES, Page A7

A now-critical voice on trans youth care

Once a leading figure in field, Amy Tishelman tells why she questions assessment process

By Mike Damiano
GLOBE STAFF

Amy Tishelman has been near the center of the field of youth transgender health for more than a decade.

A clinical psychologist, Tishelman was the director of research at Boston Children’s Hospital’s gender clinic for eight years. She was a lead author of the international standards of care for treatment of gender-diverse children.

She has also become a critic of the field she has helped shape. During courtroom testimony in late October, she called Boston Children’s Hospital’s process for assessing minors for medical transition treatments “reckless.”

The clinic, she and other clinicians testified, had shortened its in-person evaluation to determine a patient’s readiness for hormone treatments to two hours. That’s far too little time, Tishelman said, to evaluate a patient’s needs, as well as their mental health, and determine whether it is appropriate to recommend medical interven-



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

“I feel really concerned about the current state of the research, to be blunt about it,” said Amy Tishelman, formerly of Boston Children’s Hospital.

tions.

Some of her former colleagues testified that truncating the in-person assessment was appropriate, and necessary in light of the clinic’s growing wait list. Parents have also defended the clinic, known as the Gender Multispecialty

TISHELMAN, Page A10

CVS Health plans to lay off 164 workers at Hartford-based health insurer Aetna, which has struggled this year. **B6.**

On Christmas Eve, Pope Francis symbolically opened the sealed Holy Door of St. Peter’s Basilica from his wheelchair, inaugurating a jubilee year. **A4.**

Newbury Comics, a local comic book and music store chain, was accused of union-busting tactics by a national union. **B6.**

It was a big year for sports in New England, and it wasn’t just the Celtics. Here are the pictures of the year shot by Globe photographers. **C1, 4.**

Eastern Standard is still trying to hit its stride in its new location, but it appears to be on the upswing, writes Devra First. **G1.**



Very shiny glows

Wednesday: A bit milder. High 31-36. Low 23-28.

Thursday: More of the same. High 33-38. Low 20-25.

High tide: 6:43 a.m., 7:15 p.m. Sunrise: 7:12 Sunset: 4:17

Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

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CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

After the worst of the pandemic, people seem ready to get out and play. Beatrice Mahler (left) and Lu Fairbank rode Virtual Rabbids at Dx.

The standbys are here — yes, pinball’s back — but high-tech games are bringing a new jolt

By Dana Gerber
GLOBE STAFF

Decades out from their heyday, arcades are once again becoming space invaders.

From a 300-square-foot storefront in Somerville to a former pizza joint off Route 140 in Taunton, a spate of these electronic playgrounds have opened their doors across Greater Boston in the past few years.

Why the extra life? In the aftermath of the pandemic, operators found a public clamoring for experience-based brick-and-mortar spots, and communities hungry for businesses that could bring people out to play.

“Coming out of COVID, it was really clear that people had taken experiences for granted,” said Sean Hope, who got “good deals” on leases to open two locations of an arcade, called Dx, in Cambridge this year. “I felt that people really would be attracted to a curated experience that was something different than before.”

And though their inspiration may be retro, this new generation of arcades isn’t mere nostalgia bait. It’s more like a leveling-up, with these venues offering a mix of classic and high-tech games, modern pricing models, and on-site bars and restaur-

ARCADES, Page A7